

Listening at the Margins: Black Women's Oral History Approaches to Davidson's Past



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Introduction

Davidson College's official archive centers administrative records and formal student leadership narratives. The individual Black student experience remains largely absent from that record.

Through interviews with Black Davidson alumni, I treat personal memory and lived experience as legitimate historical evidence: a form of intellectual labor that institutional archives have long overlooked.

Drawing on previous scholarship, I ask:

What does Davidson's history look like when told from the inside, by students the college's official record never fully captured?

Objectives

- 1) Begin building an Alternate Archive
- 2) Apply Black feminist methodology
- 3) Avoid the Single Narrative
- 4) Contribute to Davidson's Ongoing Memory Work

QR Code for Specific Interviewee Profiles:

Janet Stovall '85
Jennifer Heath '06

Kate Endeley
Nkerbu '06

Chris Burton '08
Maia Harrell '20



Methods

- Conducted five semi-structured oral history interviews with Black alums, specifically from the 1980s-2000s
- Each interview was recorded, transcribed, and analyzed thematically
- Computationally analyzed qualitative data using Wolfram Mathematica
- Each interview was grounded in Black feminist oral history methodology (Dixon-McKnight; Frazier; Lovett; Savage; Spencer)

Results

"What Davidson taught me is that you have to create your own tables...Coming from Chicago, everything I needed already existed for me."
— Kate Endeley '06

"I think Project '87 was the first time anybody held Davidson accountable in a way that was objective...**It's always going to be up to us.**"
— Janet Stovall '85

"We have to tell our stories, or else they won't be told"
— Chris Burton '08

"Not only was **being a minority isolating** at times, but **being able to find other students who related to me** and the way I grew up **could be isolating at times.**"
— Jennifer Heath '06

"I tried to build my freshman hall to be the opposite of what mine was. Every year after that, my goal was: I never want to hear any of my Black female residents talking about the same experience that I had."
— Maia Harrell '20

"Being an Alpha at that time was great because **we were able to bring our brothers and other orgs to campus in a way that made the campus feel much more hospitable to Black people.**"
— Chris Burton '08

"Being able to say you're a 'wildcat', I knew the weight that carried in the real world. And so I was like, if I can just suffer through four years, it'll be fine when I get out."
— Maia Harrell '20

"Reverend Tapia, Dr. Fairley, and Dean Jeffries...they knew how we felt, and so they were our safe space...we could talk to them about how we were feeling."
— Jennifer Heath '06

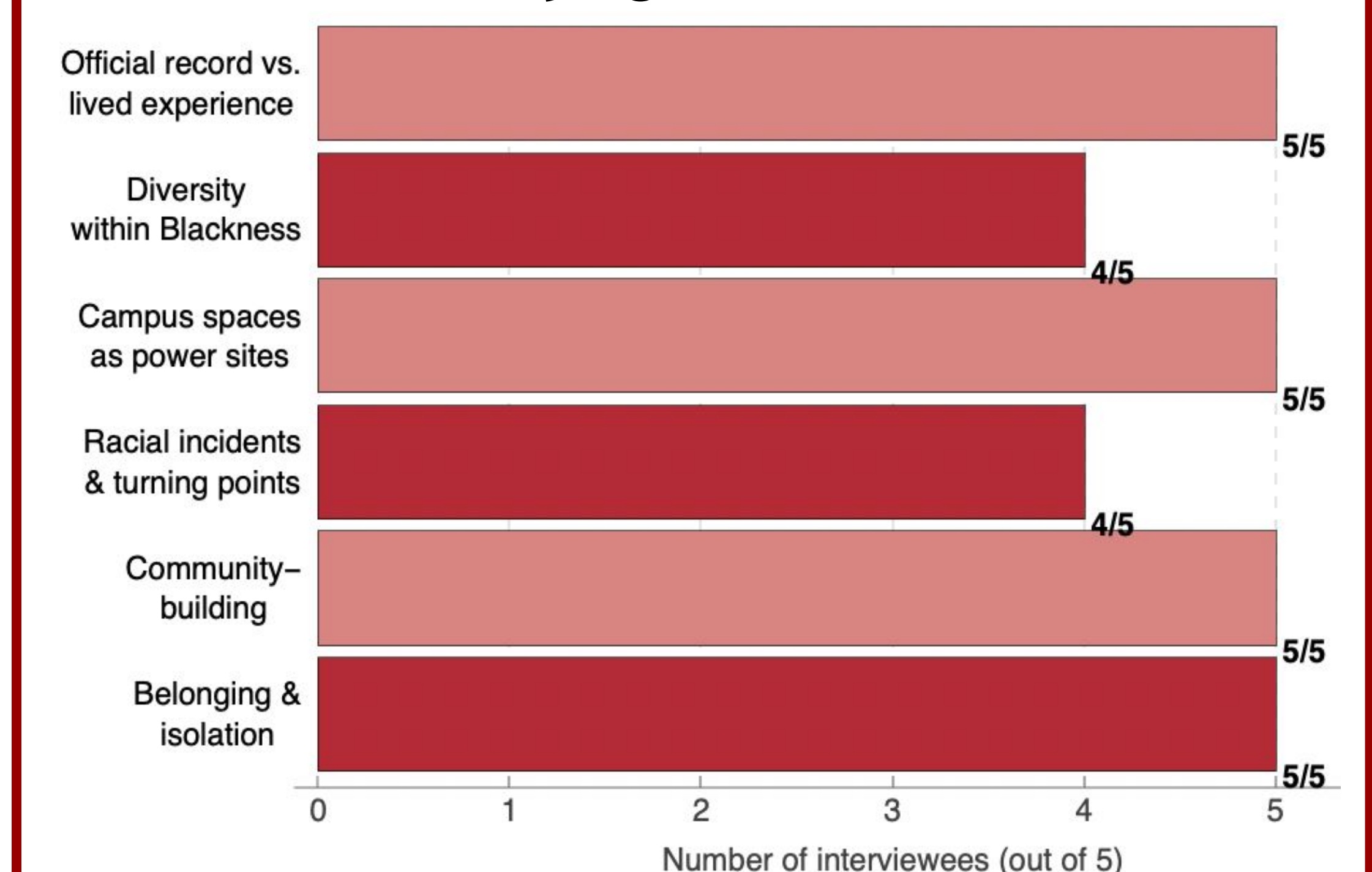
"Somebody made a Black doll, put a **noose on its neck, hung it in the hallway, and set it on fire.** I said to my dad, can I have an apartment? He goes, no. I said, **somebody just burned a statue that was supposed to be me.** He goes, okay, you can have an apartment."
— Janet Stovall '85

"The good is that you're getting the stellar education and you're being challenged in ways you have not been challenged before. But the bad is that culturally, you have to make the cultural spaces that you want to see."
— Kate Endeley '06

Conclusion

- **Generational divides:** Perspectives on legacy and recognition shift based on lived proximity to racism.
- **Not a monolith:** Black experiences at Davidson vary across diaspora and background.
- **Community vs. isolation:** Connection exists, but often alongside feelings of marginalization.
- **Advocacy through necessity:** Students developed leadership by creating space for themselves.
- **Uneven progress:** Institutional changes do not always equal lived inclusion.
- **Narratives matter:** Personal experiences complicate official accounts of progress.
- **Overall:** The Black experience at Davidson is complex, shaped by tension and ongoing dialogue.

Themes in Black Student Oral Histories, Davidson College 1985-2020



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